Testing your WAMP installation

If your WAMP default page is not displayed as shown in Figure 2, it means that all services are not running. In which case, follow either of the steps shown below:

- Left click on the icon, select *Apache*, go to the *service* option, click on the *Start/Resume* service.
- Left click on the icon and select *Restart all services*.

Now the next step to test this installation is to open up a browser and access *http://localhost*. This can also be done by clicking on the link *localhost* in the WampServer menu. This shows the project folder list which you can access to test the code being developed, as shown in Figure 2. This page shows the version information of the components such as Apache, MySQL and PHP. It also shows loaded extensions of PHP that are useful for advanced programmers. Bringing up this page only tests the Apache server. However, to check the health of the MySQL and PHP engine installations, you can refer to the *phpinfo* link on the same page. It also contains information for advanced PHP programmers, such as various PHP modules, environment variables, HTTP headers, etc. It is important to note here that the real test for the PHP engine is to write sample code and test it, while for MySQL, the test is to create a database and access it programmatically.

Setting up WAMP with special requirements

Now let's set up this installation to develop PHP code. To write a 'Hello World' program, just create a *.php* file containing code and copy it in the project folder. This project can be accessed via the *localhost* page in the browser to run the code and enhance it further. However if you're considering advanced PHP programming, you would need to enable additional modules, change execution timeout, increase memory size, etc. All these settings can be found in the *httpd.conf* file. To increase the 'execution time' of the server, open the *php.ini* file and search for *max_execution_time*, which is typically set to 30 seconds, by default. If the application being developed is going to depend heavily on the database, it is advisable to increase the timeout value to 120 seconds or more, depending on the situation. Similarly, search for the *memory_limit* variable in the file to increase the maximum amount of memory to be consumed by the script.

As for the Apache server, there may be a need to access it from a remote machine in the same network. This feature is disabled by default. To enable it, open the *httpd.conf* file and make the changes as shown in the screen below. Always remember to select *Restart All Services* from the WAMP menu for these changes to take effect.

```
<Directory "cgi-bin">
    AllowOverride None
    Options None
    Order allow,deny
    Deny from all
</Directory>
Change to
<Directory "cgi-bin">
    AllowOverride None
    Options None
   Order allow,deny
  Allow from all
</Directory>
```

Now let's create a database on the WAMP platform, which is easy. Go to *phpMyAdmin* from the *localhost* menu of the WAMP server. It will show you a list of default *databases*. Click on the *Databases* tab to create a new database, and click it to further create tables and apply privileges, etc. To ensure that the database has been created successfully, you can manually populate the table and, in the SQL tab, run a simple SELECT query to fetch the records. This ensures the database and table creation, as well as the healthy running of the database engine. There are many such settings for each component, and you can find out about them in the WAMP documentation. Be careful while changing some settings, because they could render the installation useless if not done correctly.

Back-up and maintenance

Backing up code is an easy process, because all you need to do is to copy the project folder to the back-up drive. As for database back-up, the *phpmyadmin* interface allows you to export the entire database in various formats such as *csv*, *sql*, *pdf*, *zip*, etc. To restore it, you need to simply use the import option and restart services for the import to take effect. Besides back-up, WAMP doesn't need any special maintenance as long as there is enough disk space available. For advanced programmers, occasional tuning may be required, which can be achieved by modifying the configuration files.

Summary

WAMP is a popular platform in the Windows world and it seems like it is catching up with the LAMP installation base. Ease of installation and component-based upgradability make WAMP a great development platform for serious PHP and database programmers. So, happy open source programming. END

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